after he added: “God grant that we concede in the future with such results.” But he also found it necessary to counter the critique of his main opponents in the communist camp—the Chinese. His words, though never published in the Soviet press, were addressed not only to a domestic but also to an international audience. He was clearly on the defensive as he countered Chinese arguments: “Some wiseacres say that you can’t believe the imperialists. What a discovery! So what do you do, kill him? Kill him! Those wiseacres, who teach others so well, have caught the scent of capitalist crap in their own home and tolerate Mac[ao] on their territory.… The Portuguese crap; they’ve built themselves outhouses and spend their nights in Hong Kong. And so it goes!”[11]

The party secretaries and industry managers who made up most of the audience met Khrushchev’s bravado and crude jokes with laughter and applause. He was indeed an effective and entertaining speaker, but whatever they thought of his policies as distinct from his presentation of them, they were in no position to oppose the leader or express any doubts about his actions. Any manifestation or even suspicion of disloyalty to the leader would have cost them their lives under Stalin and their careers under Khrushchev. Even so, there was growing resentment of the recklessness with which he had brought his country and the world to the verge of nuclear war, as well as of the humiliation to which he had subjected the military.

When the same members of the Central Committee voted to remove Khrushchev from power two years later, in October 1964, they applauded with equal enthusiasm as Presidium members unleashed a devastating critique of their leader for his arrogance, adventurism, and mistakes committed at home and abroad. Among the foreign policy failures, Cuba received special attention from the deputy prime minister chosen to present the accumulated grievances of Khrushchev’s underlings in the Presidium against their boss.

Deputy Premier Dmitrii Poliansky, who had kept silent during long sessions on Cuba and never previously dared to criticize Khrushchev, expressed his and his colleagues’ frustration with Khrushchev’s nuclear brinkmanship: “In one of his speeches Comrade Khrushchev stated that if the USA touched Cuba, we would strike against them. He insisted that our missiles be sent to Cuba. That produced a tremendous crisis, bringing the